



A FREE GUIDE FROM MOVING TO LONDON

The London Relocation Checklist

Every step, in order — from confirming your visa at home to registering for Council Tax after you've moved in. The sequence is the same whichever passport you're holding.

6 stages

Any nationality

Plain English

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- 01 Before You Leave Home
 - 02 Budget Worksheet
 - 03 Temporary Housing (First 2–4 Weeks)
 - 04 Your First 3 Days
 - 05 Your First Week
 - 06 Your First Month
-

BEFORE YOU START

Why this order matters

Relocating to London involves a specific sequence — a few things can only be done before you leave home, a few only after you land, and a couple of registrations quietly carry deadlines nobody mentions until you've missed them (Council Tax is the classic one). This guide lays out that sequence, stage by stage, so nothing catches you out at the point it actually matters.

It's written to apply regardless of your home country or specific visa route — for the visa route itself, see the separate Visas & Immigration guide, or GOV.UK directly, since eligibility rules are updated on their own schedule and are worth confirming independently of this checklist.

Quick glossary

NI number

National Insurance number — needed to be paid correctly and to access some benefits.

eVisa

The UK's digital immigration status record — physical BRP cards are no longer issued, so this is now the standard for almost everyone.

GP

General Practitioner — your NHS primary doctor, and the entry point to non-emergency healthcare.

Council Tax

A monthly local tax based on your property's valuation band — separate from rent or a mortgage.

The paperwork you can only get right before you go

Everything here happens on home soil — some of it weeks before your flight.

Skipping ahead on this stage is what causes the most expensive mistakes later — a bank account you can't open remotely, a shipment you didn't book in time, or a visa condition you didn't confirm before giving notice at your current job.

- ☐ Confirm your visa or right-to-work status is fully approved and in hand before booking flights or giving notice at your current job

- ☐ Gather key documents: passport, visa/eVisa confirmation, proof of address, employment contract or offer letter, academic or professional certificates, and any family documents needed for dependants

- ☐ Start a UK bank account application if your bank offers remote or pre-arrival setup — not all do, so check early

- ☐ Notify your current bank of the move, and consider a multi-currency card (Wise, Revolut, or similar) to bridge the gap before a UK account is active

- ☐ Order a UK SIM in advance so it's ready to activate the day you land, or plan to buy one on arrival

- ☐ Take a passport-style photo — you'll need one again for several separate applications

- ☐ If you're bringing belongings, book an international mover or freight shipment well ahead of your date — this takes longer to arrange than people expect

- ☐ Confirm your first few weeks of accommodation are booked before you leave (see Stage 03)

DID YOU KNOW

Some UK banks let non-residents start an account before arrival, but most still require a UK address and in-person or video ID verification — "remote setup" rarely means fully done before you land.

KNOW BEFORE YOU GO

- Book 2–4 weeks of accommodation before you fly — don't plan to house-hunt in person from day one
- If your visa depends on employer sponsorship, confirm your start date lines up with sponsorship activation, not just your flight date

What actually shows up on a monthly budget

Work this out before you commit to renting or buying — not after.

The real cost of living in London depends heavily on which area you choose — that's what the neighbourhood guides and the Cost of Living guide are for. But the categories below are universal, and they're worth filling in *before* Stage 03, while you're still deciding what you can actually afford to commit to.

Category	£ per month
Rent or mortgage	
Council Tax	
Utilities & broadband	
Transport (contactless cap)	
Mobile phone	
Groceries	
TV Licence (if applicable)	
Insurance (contents / health top-up)	
Discretionary / social	
Emergency buffer	
Total	

DID YOU KNOW

A TV Licence is genuinely easy to miss — it's legally required to watch or record live TV on any channel or service, including BBC iPlayer. On-demand viewing elsewhere (Netflix, Prime Video, All 4) doesn't need one, which is what catches people out about the distinction.

Almost nobody moves straight into their permanent home

First 2–4 weeks, before the real search starts.

Most relocators book short-term or serviced accommodation first, then search for a permanent place once they're on the ground and can actually view properties. Signing a long-term tenancy from abroad, sight unseen, is usually a mistake — and with your Stage 02 budget already worked out, you'll know what you're actually shopping within.

- ☐ Book short-term or serviced accommodation for at least your first 2 weeks, ideally 4
- ☐ Have proof of funds and a reference letter (from an employer or previous landlord) ready — UK agents move fast and expect these upfront
- ☐ Understand that most permanent tenancies expect a UK bank account, and often a guarantor or several months' rent upfront without a UK credit history
- ☐ Start browsing neighbourhoods before you land so you're not choosing blind once you arrive

DID YOU KNOW

A UK rental deposit is legally capped at five weeks' rent for tenancies under £50,000 a year in rent — true for almost every standard London letting. But without a UK guarantor or credit history, agents often ask for several months' rent upfront instead, which isn't a deposit and isn't protected the same way.

KNOW BEFORE YOU GO

- Bring printed and digital copies of your proof of funds and references — some agents still want paper
- Start viewing permanent properties as soon as you land; the properties worth having move fast

The essentials that make everything else possible

A working phone and a way to pay for transport, before anything else.

These first few tasks unlock almost everything else on this list — you need a working phone and a way to move around the city before you can do much of anything.

- ☐ Activate your UK SIM or buy one — major providers (EE, O2, Three, Vodafone) have shops at major airports and stations

- ☐ Use a contactless bank card or phone payment directly on the Tube, buses, and Overground — no separate transport card is required unless you prefer one

- ☐ Locate your nearest GP practice, even though registration itself may take a few more days (Stage 05)

- ☐ If your UK bank account isn't already open, book your in-branch or video verification appointment now

DID YOU KNOW

London's contactless daily and weekly fare caps apply automatically — the system stops charging once you hit the maximum for the zones you've travelled in. The "day" runs 04:30 to 04:29 the next morning, not midnight to midnight, and the weekly cap runs Monday to Sunday.

KNOW BEFORE YOU GO

- Keep your passport and visa/eVisa confirmation on you for these first few appointments — you'll be asked for ID more than once

The paperwork that unlocks work and healthcare

Two things to start immediately — neither is instant.

This is the week the essential admin gets done. The two big ones are your National Insurance number and GP registration — both worth starting right away since neither happens overnight.

- ☐ Check your eVisa profile or BRP for a National Insurance (NI) number first — most sponsored work visas have one auto-issued as part of the immigration application. If it's not there, you can only apply once you're physically in the UK, and it takes up to 4 weeks

- ☐ Register with a local GP practice — you can typically do this before you have a permanent address, using your temporary accommodation

- ☐ Finish setting up your UK bank account if not already done

- ☐ Choose and activate a proper UK mobile plan (monthly contract vs. pay-as-you-go) once you know you're staying

- ☐ Start viewing permanent properties in earnest — a buyer's or renting advisor who knows the local market saves real time here

DID YOU KNOW

Registering with a GP doesn't require ID, proof of address, or proof of immigration status — you can register with a temporary address and update your details later, so there's no reason to wait until you've settled.

KNOW BEFORE YOU GO

- Your NI number is one of the most-requested pieces of ID in the UK system — check for it now even if you don't need it immediately for work

Making the move official

None of this is automatic, and some of it has real deadlines.

Once you've signed a permanent tenancy or moved into a purchased home, a handful of registrations become your responsibility — nobody chases you for these, but a few carry deadlines that are easy to miss.

- ☐ Sign your permanent tenancy or complete your property purchase

- ☐ Register for Council Tax through your specific local council's own website as soon as possible after moving — there's no single national system, and nothing happens automatically

- ☐ Set up utilities (energy, water, broadband) in your name at the new address

- ☐ Update your address with your bank, employer, visa sponsor, GP practice, and any UK government accounts

- ☐ Register to vote if you're eligible — Commonwealth citizens and some EU nationals can register for local council elections without British citizenship, even where they can't vote in general elections

- ☐ If you have children, start school registration — many London boroughs run in-year admissions separately from the standard annual cycle, and it can take longer than expected

DID YOU KNOW

Council Tax bands were set decades ago based on historic property values, not current prices — so two similarly priced homes in different areas can sit in very different bands.

KNOW BEFORE YOU GO

- Broadband and energy contracts typically run 12–18 months, and switching early usually carries an exit fee — worth checking before you sign
- As of the Renters' Rights Act, most new tenancies are now rolling by default with no fixed term — you give two months' notice to leave, and a landlord needs a specific legal reason to end it, not just notice

READY TO START LOOKING?

Six stages down. One decision left.

Every stage above gets easier with someone who already knows the London market from the buyer's or renter's side — not just a listing agent's goodwill.

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